

depending on the environment you are in and head gestures, which allow you to accept and decline calls by moving your head. There are a ton of features which I honestly would not like to spill the beans on. Just know that they are great and you will enjoy them when you find out about them one by one. One thing I would not want you to miss out on is the DSEE Extreme. This upscaling tech is one of the best I have seen in an app, and it does a really good job of making sure that the details in the songs, when you are streaming, are of lower quality. Talking about the sound quality while streaming, you have support for Sony's LDAC CODEC, which allows you to stream high-quality music. However, when I was using these earbuds on my PC, I experienced noticeable latency when gaming or taking calls. But if you are on your phone, then that is not an issue at all.

The on-ear detection and multipoint connectivity worked like a charm on my all-Apple setup at home, which I think is a testament to the fact that Sony has all its bases covered well when it comes to quality-of-life features on these earbuds. With that said, I do not have anything to complain about with the features part of these earbuds. They are loaded with features that have been implemented well. I would expect nothing less from a pair of flagship TWS earbuds from a brand like Sony. And they deliver on all the promises made. Now, let's look at the improvements made in terms of the features.

PERFORMANCE

In terms of performance, there was nothing that came close to the Sony WF-1000XM5 this year. The earbuds sport a slightly bass-heavy sound signature. As you can see, there is a subtle boost in the lows, which is fairly apparent when you are listening to the earbuds. The mids come pretty close to our reference flat response of Pink Noise. In the highs, there is a boost as well, which rounds up the sound signature fairly well. These earbuds won the hearts of everyone at the Test Centre. Across genres, the sound was pleasant, and with some tuning in the Sony Headphones Connect App, you can get results that ensure

that you won't have any problems when listening to podcasts, heavy metal music, or bass-laden EDM tracks. The boominess in the bass is not overwhelming, and there is no concerning sibilance in the audio in the high end. When compared to the WF-1000XM4, the last-gen Sony flagship TWS earbuds, the 1000XM5 have brought in tons of improvements. I would like to borrow a line from my Zero1 Awards article here – These earbuds, with their well-rounded sound signature and ANC, both of which have seen an improvement over last year's 1000XM4, outclassed the competition by a mile. When you have ANC turned on, there is a minuscule change in the sound signature. However, it is nothing that would bother you a lot.

Coming to the ANC, Sony has outclassed itself with these earbuds. The only other pair of TWS earbuds that I can think of, which blocks off sound, as well as the Sony WF-1000XM5, are the Bose QC Earbuds II, which are widely regarded as the industry leaders in this performance metric. The ANC on the 1000XM5, coupled with the improved fit, thanks to the smaller size of the buds and the foam ear tips, definitely improves the overall user experience. Now, given that both ANC and the sound signature depend heavily on the fit of the buds, their reduced size is something that a lot of people would appreciate. There are some sharp frequencies which the Sony let in when I was in traffic; especially those of the shrill-sounding vehicles and horns. That is something I would love brands in general to work more on in terms of cancellation. Other than that, no complaints from my end in terms of the ANC of the WF-1000XM5.

As for the microphone on these earbuds, it held its own, even in challenging conditions. In the office, the buds did not face any problems in terms of cancelling out the sounds of the AC and people talking in the background. Even in games, these earbuds did not cause any issues in terms of audio latency or my audio not being heard clearly by my teammates.

BATTERY LIFE

The Sony WF-1000XM5 boast a battery life of 8 hours of battery life on the earbuds

with 16 hours of battery in the case. In my testing, with ANC on and volume set to 90dB SPL, the Sony WF-1000XM5 lasted about 8 hours and 5 minutes, which is over the claimed battery life of the buds. Sony is over-delivering the promises that they made. Always a win-win. The Headphones Connect app sends out a notification when the battery level stops below 30 per cent. And, if you are out of charge, a three-minute charge, as claimed by Sony, gives you 60 minutes of playback.

VERDICT

The Sony WF-1000XM5 are one of the best pairs of TWS earbuds available in the market today. They build up on the legacy of their predecessors, the WF-1000XM4, and make sure that you get the worth for the money you are spending on them. That is why they clinched the Digit Zero1 Award and the Best Buy Award 2023 in the Best Performing Premium TWS earbuds category. The only alternative to these earbuds that I can recommend are the Bose QC Earbuds II. They are also well rounded in terms of sound signature and ANC performance, but one front they lack on, is the features. So, the Sony makes for a more holistic user experience, while the QC Earbuds II are what I would recommend to the more hard core performance enthusiast.

–Satvik Pandey

SPECIFICATIONS

Colour: Platinum Silver, Black | Weight: Approx. 5.9 g x2 | Headphone Type: Closed, dynamic | Driver unit: 8.4 mm | Frequency Response (Bluetooth® Communication): 20–20,000 Hz (44.1 kHz sampling) | 20–40,000 Hz (LDAC 96 kHz sampling 990 kbps) | Volume Control: Yes | Waterproof: Yes (IPX4 equivalent) | DSEE Extreme: Yes | Ambient Sound Mode: Yes | Battery Charge Time: Approx. 1.5 hrs | Battery Life (Continuous Music Playback Time): Max. 8 hrs (NC ON) | Max. 12 hrs (NC OFF) | Battery Life (Continuous Communication Time): Max. 6 hrs (NC ON) | Max. 7 hrs (NC OFF) | Bluetooth® Version: Bluetooth Specification Version 5.3 | Effective Range: 10 m | Frequency Range: 2.4 GHz band (2.4000 GHz - 2.4835 GHz) | Profile: A2DP, AVRCP, HFP, HSP, TMAP, CSIP, MCP, VCP, CCP | Supported Audio Format(s): SBC, AAC, LDAC, LC3

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